

Collective Intelligence — Module 08: Planning —

Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on collective planning, emergent strategy, participatory foresight, and bottom-up intelligence.

1. How does Mintzberg's concept of "emergent strategy" challenge the top-down planning paradigm? Is emergent strategy a feature or a bug?
2. When does emergent strategy produce coherent outcomes, and when does it produce strategic drift? What determinants influence the outcome?
3. Toyota's A3 process empowers frontline workers to drive improvement. How does this contribute to collective planning? What are its limitations?
4. Compare the Delphi method with a standard committee meeting for strategic planning. Which produces better collective judgment?
5. How does backcasting (starting from a desired future) overcome the anchoring bias that afflicts traditional planning?
6. When should planning be top-down (executive-driven), and when should it be bottom-up (participatory)? What factors determine the optimal balance?
7. How do planning cells (random employee groups deliberating on strategic issues) contribute to planning quality? What are the risks?
8. In your experience, how much of your organization's realized strategy was deliberate versus emergent? How would you know the difference?
9. How does the quality of collective planning change with group size? Is a planning workshop with 10 people better or worse than one with 100?
10. How do incentive structures affect the quality of bottom-up intelligence in planning? Will employees share honest strategic observations if doing so is risky?

11. If participatory planning produces better strategies, why do most organizations still plan top-down? What institutional barriers prevent participation?
12. Evaluate your organization's most recent planning process. Was it participatory? Did it incorporate bottom-up intelligence? What would you change?
13. Design a scenario workshop for your team involving 8-12 participants from different functions. Specify the pre-work, workshop structure, and output format.
14. Your CEO wants to incorporate frontline employee insights into the annual strategic plan. Design a mechanism that collects, aggregates, and presents bottom-up intelligence to the executive team.
15. Apply the futures wheel method to a significant trend in your industry. Map first-order, second-order, and third-order consequences.
16. Your organization's formal strategy says one thing, but the pattern of actual resource allocation says something different. How would you surface this gap using collective planning methods?
17. Compare how planning functions in a military organization (top-down with distributed adaptation) versus a cooperative (democratic decision-making). What can corporate planning learn from each?
18. How should collective planning incorporate dissenting views? Design a process that ensures minority perspectives influence the final plan.
19. A planning workshop produces 50 strategic ideas. Design an aggregation and prioritization process that preserves collective intelligence rather than defaulting to the highest-ranking person's preference.
20. How frequently should an organization engage in collective planning? Is an annual offsite sufficient, or should planning be a continuous process?